Riverdale, the university was large, imparting to its environment a sense of impersonalism.

The insecurity, Ratan recalls, made him write ‘more letters home’ than at ‘any other time’. But as replies took weeks to reach, they brought him delayed relief and not when he needed it the most. The letters provided no consolation when he was gripped by bouts of anxiety. The telephone was the only answer at such times. But there was just one payphone on the ground floor of the fraternity building, he recalls. More often than not, there was quite a queue of eager students waiting to talk to their parents or girlfriends.

This made it difficult for Ratan to call home at will. It also made long conversations difficult as anyone who was on the phone for a prolonged period suffered anxious stares from impatient students waiting in line. The situation was often a little better for Ratan as he mostly needed to use the phone at night to adjust to the time difference with India. At such times, the rush was comparatively less.

Ratan’s parents too were aware that he was having difficulties adjusting to the new environment. Naval Tata regularly visited Geneva to attend the meetings of the International Labour Organization (ILO), with which he was closely associated. Occasionally, after his visits to Geneva, he flew to the US to meet Ratan. It helped the barely eighteen-year-old fight homesickness.

When he visited his son, Naval Tata met up with Barger, who became a good friend. It led to the dorm counsellor giving Ratan a little more attention. To him, Ratan came from India, a country situated half the world away and of which most Americans in the 1950s had little or no idea. The huge distance that prevented Ratan from going home except during long holidays also made Barger sympathetic to his dilemma.

As a token of his gratitude, Naval invited Barger to visit India as a guest of the family. In 1956, Barger, along with two friends from Cornell, visited India and stayed at Tata House. They were treated as ‘preferred guests’ by Lady Tata, whom he describes as one of the ‘most glorious, lovely women’ he had ever met.

At Cornell, Ratan was known as a thorough gentleman. He was described as a very ‘thoughtful guy’ who was ‘sensitive to the feeling of others’ and ‘aware of the larger world’. He was also described as an ‘intelligent, respectful, friendly, gracious and caring person’. But that did not make him